

Incident response: the first 30 minutes

The bottleneck in the first half hour is rarely diagnosis.
It is that nobody said who is in charge, and nobody told anyone else.

Three failures, none of them technical

[FAILURE 01]

**Everyone debugs.
Nobody speaks.**

The interesting problem pulls in every pair of hands. Stakeholders go quiet, then arrive asking — and the asking slows the fix.

[FAILURE 02]

**Nobody says who
is in charge.**

With no declared owner, every call needs consensus. Two people restart the same service; nobody owns the rollback.

[FAILURE 03]

**The timeline is
reconstructed.**

Nobody writes while it happens. The review then argues about the order of events, from memory, instead of the cause.

Not one of these is a diagnosis problem. Each is a decision nobody made.

Three roles, defined by what they don't do

[COMMANDER]

// DOES

Declares, assigns each role by name, decides, and keeps the log.

// DOES NOT

Touch a terminal. A commander who debugs is no longer commanding.

[COMMS]

// DOES

Writes to stakeholders on cadence, including when nothing changed.

// DOES NOT

Diagnose, or promise a fix time. “We don’t know yet” is a full update.

[INVESTIGATOR]

// DOES

One hypothesis at a time — tested, and the result said out loud.

// DOES NOT

Answer stakeholders, or change production without announcing it.

Five checkpoints, not a clock

[CHECKPOINT] EACH ONE IS PASSED, NOT SCHEDULED

// NO CLOCK, NO MINUTE MARKERS

// 01 DECLARE Someone says the word out loud. Ambiguity ends there.

// 02 ASSIGN Commander, comms, investigator — named, in the channel.

// 03 STABILISE Restore service first; the cause can wait for the review.

// 04 COMMUNICATE The first update goes out before anyone knows the cause.

// 05 RECORD The log is written while it happens, or it is fiction.

What each severity level obliges

LEVEL	WHEN IT APPLIES	WHAT IT OBLIGES	WHO IT WAKES
SEV-1	Customers blocked. No workaround exists.	Declare first, diagnose second.	On-call, service owner, duty exec.
SEV-2	Degraded. A workaround exists and it costs someone.	Commander named. Updates on cadence.	On-call and service owner.
SEV-3	Contained fault. No customer impact yet.	One owner. No separate comms role.	On-call only.
SEV-4	Known and tolerated. Tracked, not chased.	A ticket, not a page.	Nobody, until working hours.

What we need to decide

[Q1] Who may declare — and must they ask first? [BLOCKS SEV-1]

[Q2] What is our comms cadence, and who owns it? [BLOCKS COMMS]

[Q3] Where does the log live, and who writes it? [BLOCKS REVIEW]

None of this needs a tool. It needs a decision.